receiving from the Americans, nor would it look eastward for a South Asian solution. In fact, by hosting an Islamic conference, Islamabad also intended to reduce any possibility of an India-Iran strategic rapprochement, the possibility of which had increased after the 1979 Iranian revolution.[51] Agha Shahi, Pakistan's foreign minister, informed Rao of this Iranian angle over a lunch meeting in New York a few weeks after Rao's visit to Pakistan. The only success of Rao's 1981 Pakistan tour was the institution of the Indo-Pakistan Joint Commission in 1982 to facilitate trade and commerce. Zia paid a return visit to Delhi on 1 November 1982, and talks to establish the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) were initiated. Nonetheless, differences between the two countries were far from resolved. Pakistan's refusal to cut support for the Mujahideen paved the way for Gandhi to credibly defend her pro-Soviet stand on Afghanistan.

Gandhi's outreach to Pakistan was driven by contradictions that betrayed the impracticability of a peace process under geopolitical duress. Expecting not just an aggressive Pakistani response to the Soviet intervention, New Delhi was also worried about Pakistan building a nuclear bomb with Libyan help.[52] To counter these moves on the ground, Gandhi ordered then R&AW chief, G. C. 'Gary' Saxena (with former chief R. N. Kao as Gandhi's security advisor) to reactivate contacts with the Sindhi, Pashtun, and Baloch nationalists in Pakistan with whom India had contacts during the 1970s. They were not to be armed just yet, but the ground was to be prepared for such an eventuality. Many separatist leaders from Pakistan started visiting India covertly soon after the Soviet intervention (a fact that was probably known to Zia).[53] This was not the case for the brief period of non-Congress rule. Both Morarji Desai and Charan Singh had toned down R&AW's capabilities and operations, mostly out of spite (they viewed R&AW as a vanguard organisation that Gandhi misused during the Emergency in mid-1970s).

Gandhi reversed this policy and wanted the R&AW-KhAD-KGB relationship to deepen. In addition to clandestine visits by low-level separatists, prominent Pasthun leaders such as Wali Khan and Abdul Ghaffar Khan visited India openly. It was in context of this momentum of Gandhi's 'covert policy' towards Afghanistan and Pakistan in early 1980s that Abdul Ghaffar Khan was